

SIPRA DAS



BLAME GAME: The NIC meeting

the next government.

During the meeting, Prime Minister Manmohan Singh tried to bring in a note of gravitas, warning against profiling of terrorists but the meeting ended in a verbal scuffle with the NDA and the UPA taking potshots at each other.

The NIC was set up in 1961 by Jawaharlal Nehru to promote communal harmony. It has held 14 meetings so far; none have been organised by the NDA. One reason why Manmohan called this meeting was that his Government lacked the necessary numbers in Parliament to impose President's rule in NDA-ruled Orissa and Karnataka. He was hoping to use this forum to censure them. In the end, it was his Government that ended up in the dock.

by Priya Sahgal

NIC Knackered

DELHI The National Integration Council (NIC) proved to be quite a misnomer with the Congress and the BJP taking potshots at each other even before it met. Strangely enough for a council that was meeting after three years, the Government

circulated the agenda just a night before, prompting BJP chief ministers Narendra Modi and Vasundhara Raje to demand that terrorism be included in the agenda.

Curiously, L.K. Advani was conspicuous by his absence. An angry

Sushma Swaraj pointed out that he was invited in his capacity as an eminent member and not as leader of the Opposition, with his name figuring at number 137 on the invite list. Leader of the Opposition in the Rajya Sabha Jaswant Singh was not invited at all. Swaraj added ominously that this was a bad precedent for

THE BUZZ OF THE WEEK

The Congress-CPI(M) spat is getting hotter and bitter. A Politburo member's remark that a certain Congressman knows nothing about the N-deal brought forth the retort, 'I don't have to learn about the deal from an airhostess'.

VOICES



"You can't understand the Bajrang Dal by sitting in an office. See it on the field and you will understand it."

Ashok Kapoor, Bajrang Dal convener

"It is with my walking stick that we will unfurl the saffron flag atop Mantralaya (state secretariat). This stick is needed to shoo away monkeys who are ruling the state."

Bal Thackeray, Shiv Sena supremo

"Every bone in my body is secular. I don't think any of those bones have been damaged. I have not let down anyone in my state, to whichever community they belong."

Naveen Patnaik, Orissa chief minister

"Where is the money in the global market? Who will bring in the money? These are ornamental theories which serve no purpose. The Indian market is robust enough to sustain any crisis."

Kamal Nath, commerce and industry minister

"They (Australians) talk about getting a run rate of four per over. It's just all talk. Their spinners couldn't do us any harm. That tells everyone what their spin attack is all about."

Zaheer Khan, cricketer

